

04

Building the Center Correctly

When e4 belongs, when d4 is stronger, and how to prevent Black from receiving a perfect pawn center.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will use the KIA as a flexible center-selection system instead of committing to d3-e4 regardless of Black's setup.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 019 | PAGE 4

Decode: Delayed e4 against ...c5

Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

LESSON 020 | PAGE 8

Play: Delayed e4 against ...c5

Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

LESSON 021 | PAGE 12

Decode: Meeting Black's ...e5 center

Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

LESSON 022 | PAGE 16

Play: Meeting Black's ...e5 center

Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

LESSON 023 | PAGE 20

Decode: Choosing d4 instead of d3

The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

LESSON 024 | PAGE 24

Play: Choosing d4 instead of d3

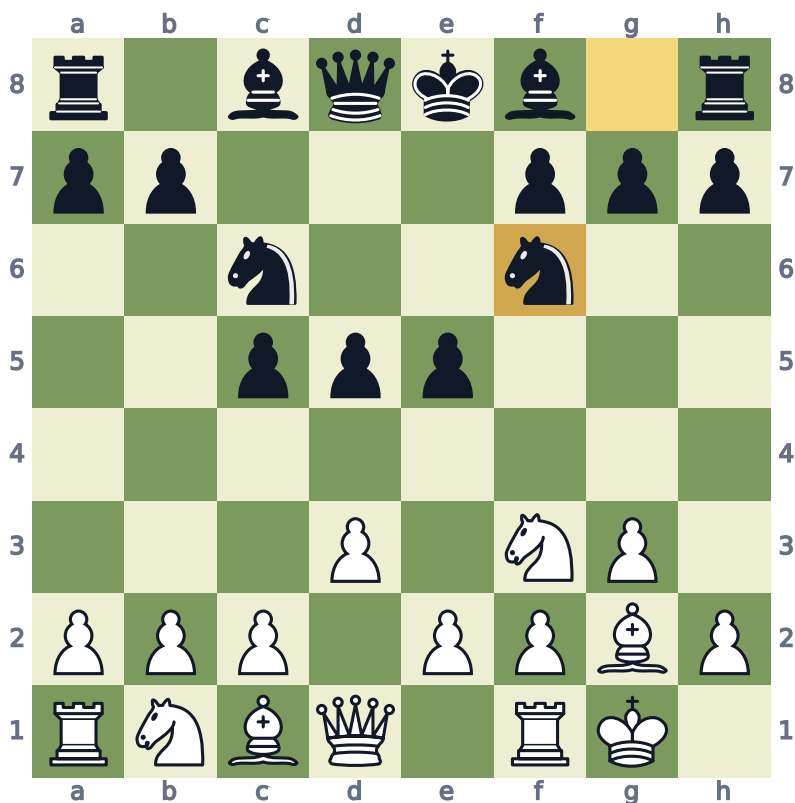
The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will use the KIA as a flexible center-selection system instead of committing to d3-e4 regardless of Black's setup.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Delayed e4 against ...c5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

DECISION RULE

After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside.

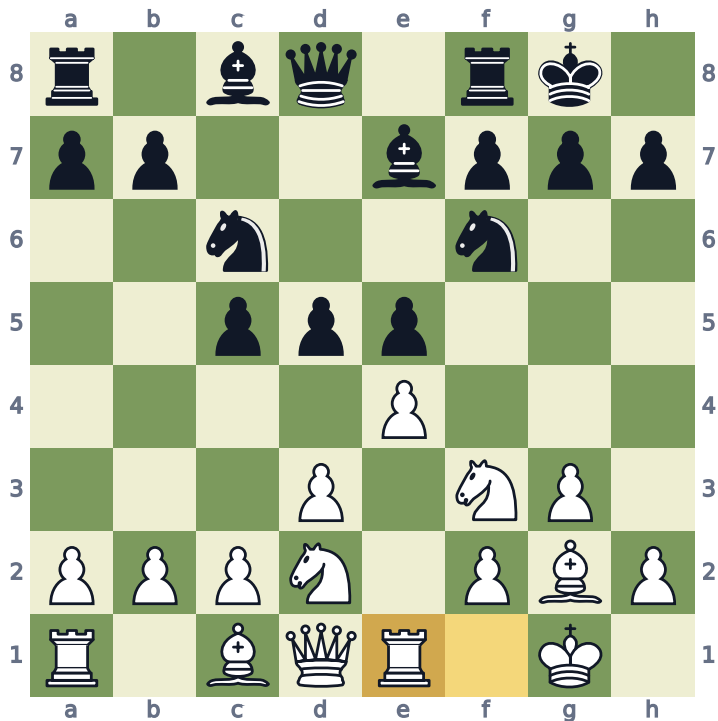
WHITE'S PLAN

White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed.

MEMORY RULE | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed.

FAILURE MODE

Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

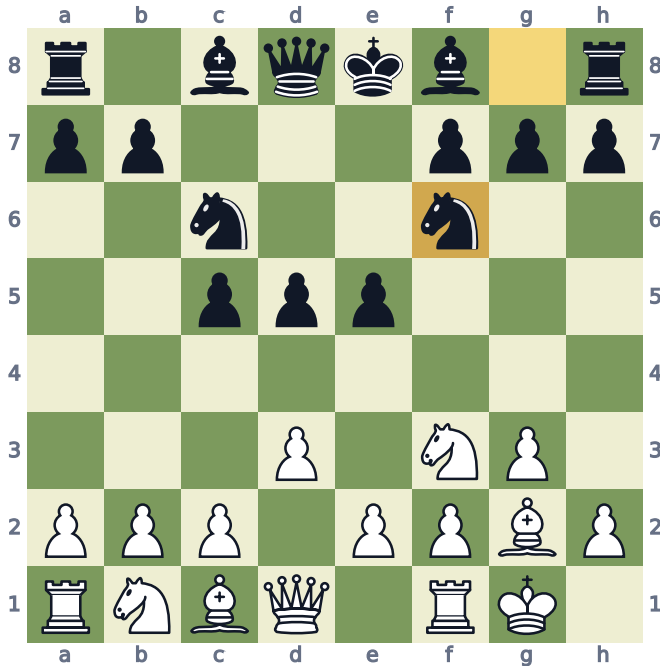
RULE | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 c5 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6 6. Nbd2 Be7 7. e4 O-O 8. Re1



- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- e5: Black builds a symmetrical center that requires White to create a new pawn break.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? White's attacking or positional plan is: White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed. The line fails as a template when: Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

STORE THIS | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

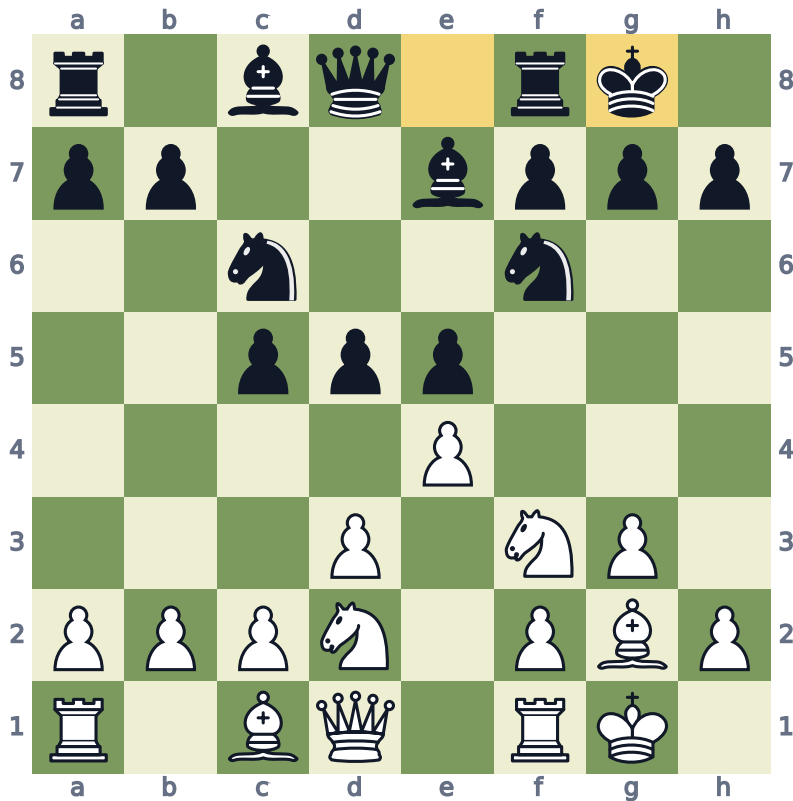
1. When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4. 2. Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside. 3. White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed. 4. After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? 5. Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Delayed e4 against ...c5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

DECISION RULE

After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside.

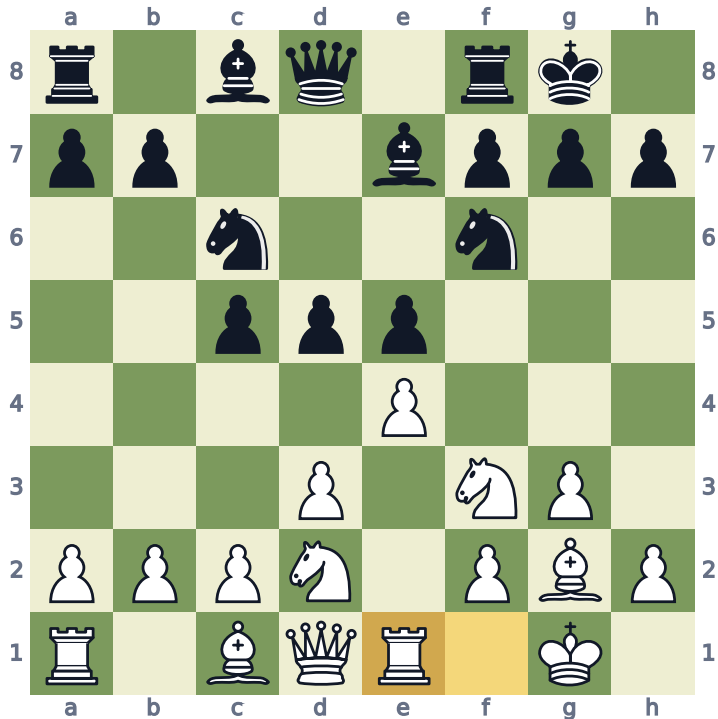
WHITE'S PLAN

White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed.

MEMORY RULE | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed.

FAILURE MODE

Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

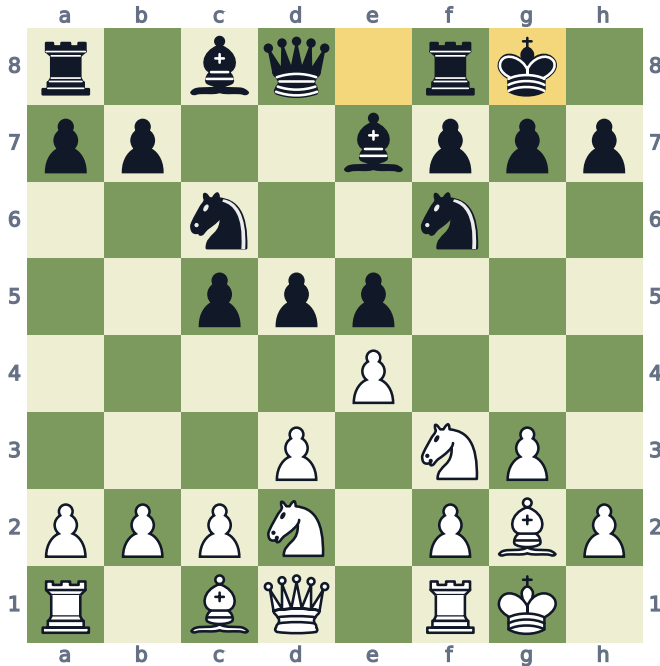
RULE | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 c5 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6 6. Nbd2 Be7 7. e4 O-O 8. Re1



- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? White's attacking or positional plan is: White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed. The line fails as a template when: Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

STORE THIS | Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

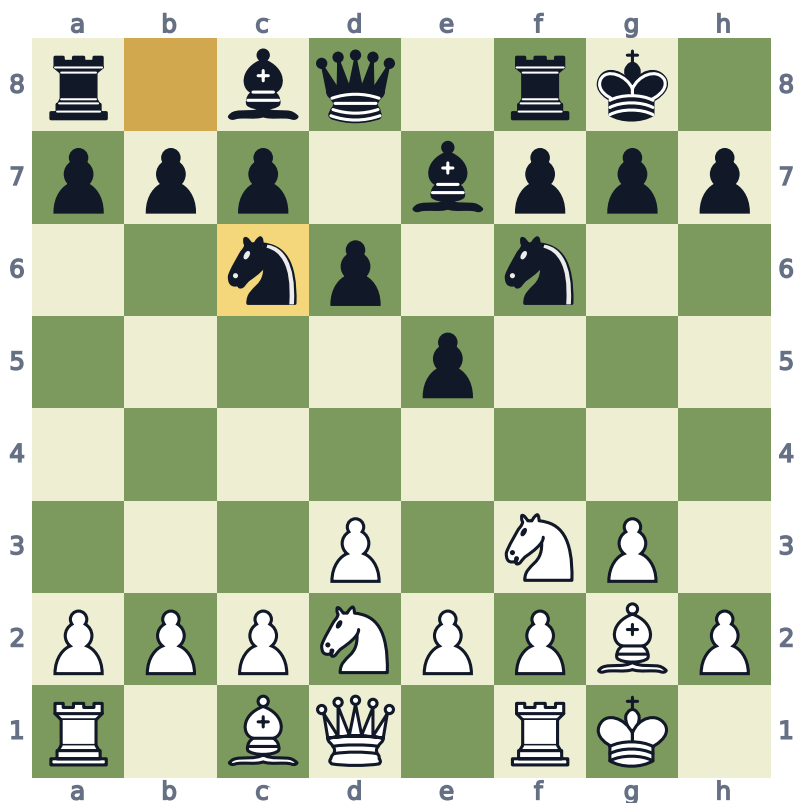
1. When Black builds ...d5 and ...c5, White's delayed e4 creates a closed center only if the resulting space and piece routes justify allowing ...d4. 2. Black may advance ...d4, gain space, and use the queenside while White is still organizing the kingside. 3. White decides whether to accept the closed center, challenge with c3, or switch to c4 pressure before the space deficit becomes fixed. 4. After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain? 5. Completing the KIA center when Black's broad center can close under ideal conditions.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 Nf6 6. Nbd2 Be7 7. e4 O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Meeting Black's ...e5 center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

DECISION RULE

Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup.

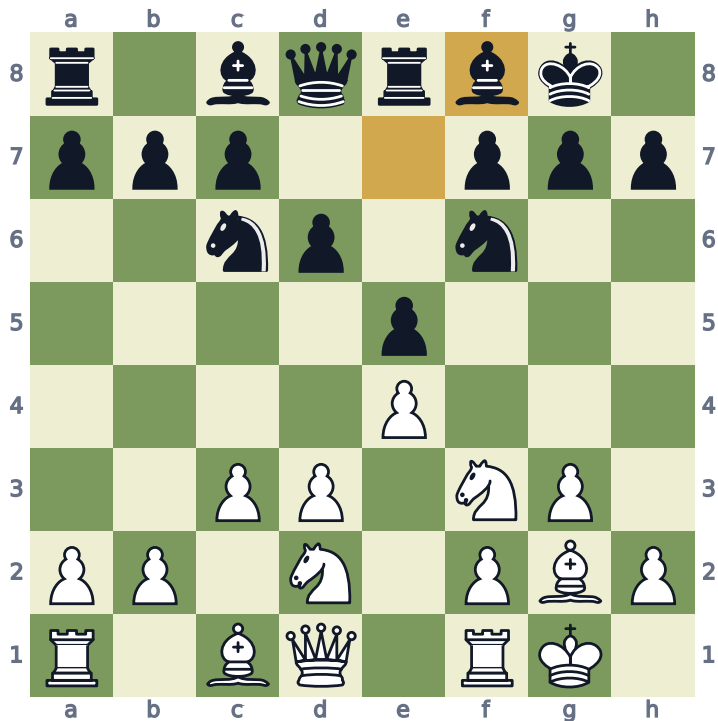
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan.

MEMORY RULE | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan.

FAILURE MODE

Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

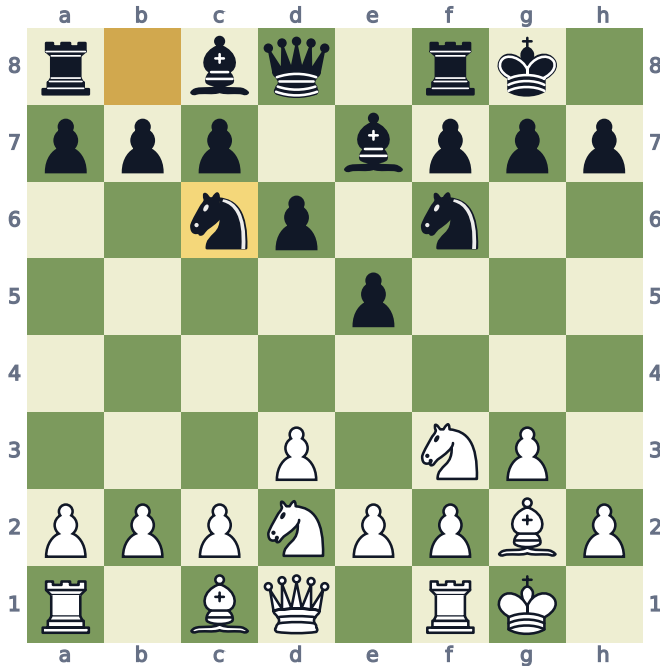
RULE | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan. The line fails as a template when: Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

STORE THIS | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

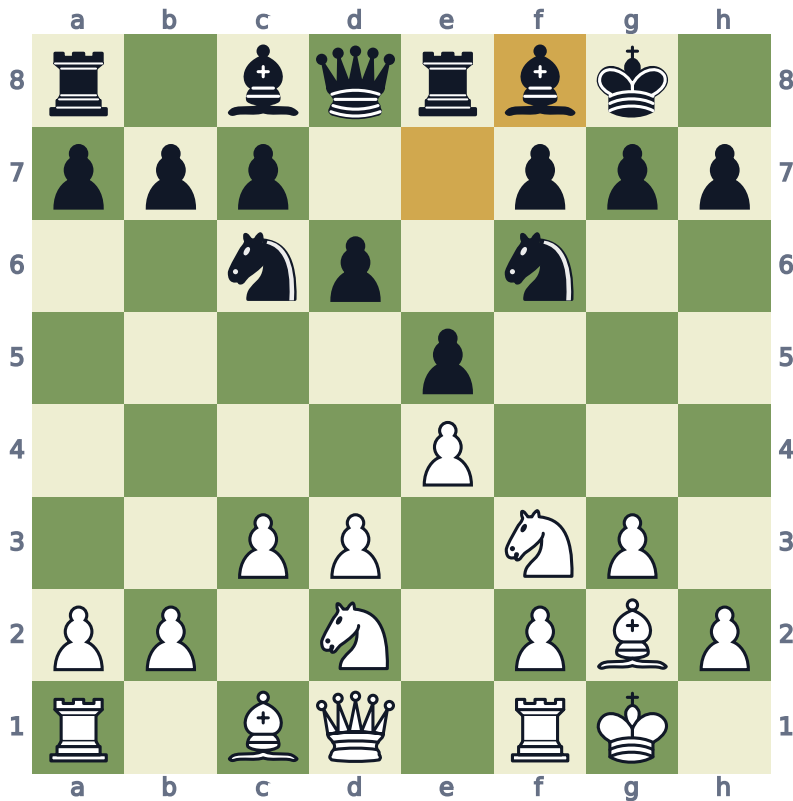
1. When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge. 2. Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup. 3. White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan. 4. Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? 5. Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Meeting Black's ...e5 center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

DECISION RULE

Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup.

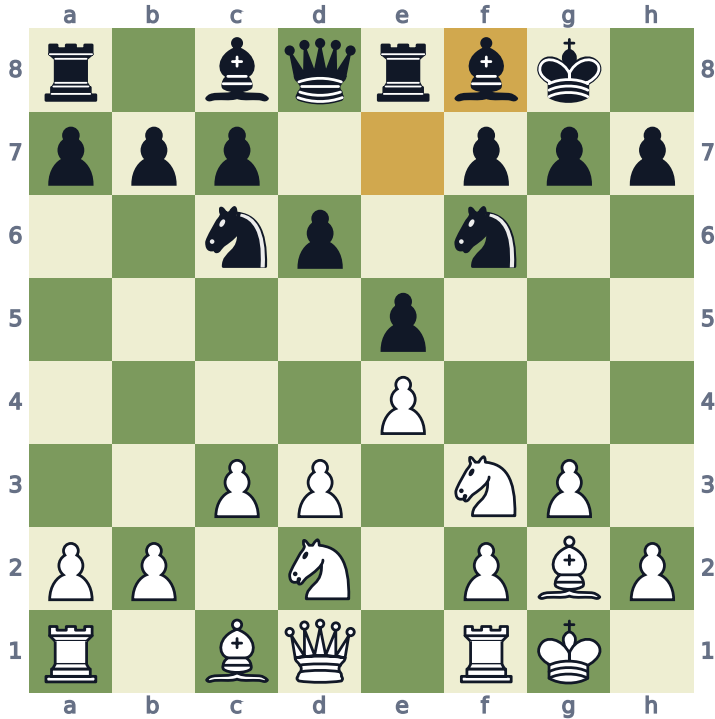
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan.

MEMORY RULE | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan.

FAILURE MODE

Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

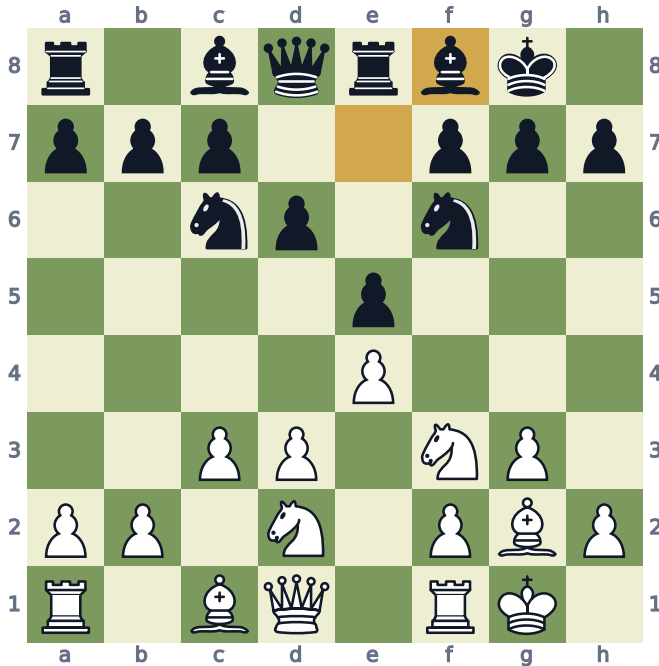
RULE | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8



- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- c3: White restrains d4 and prepares a central d4 break.
- Bf8: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan. The line fails as a template when: Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

STORE THIS | Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

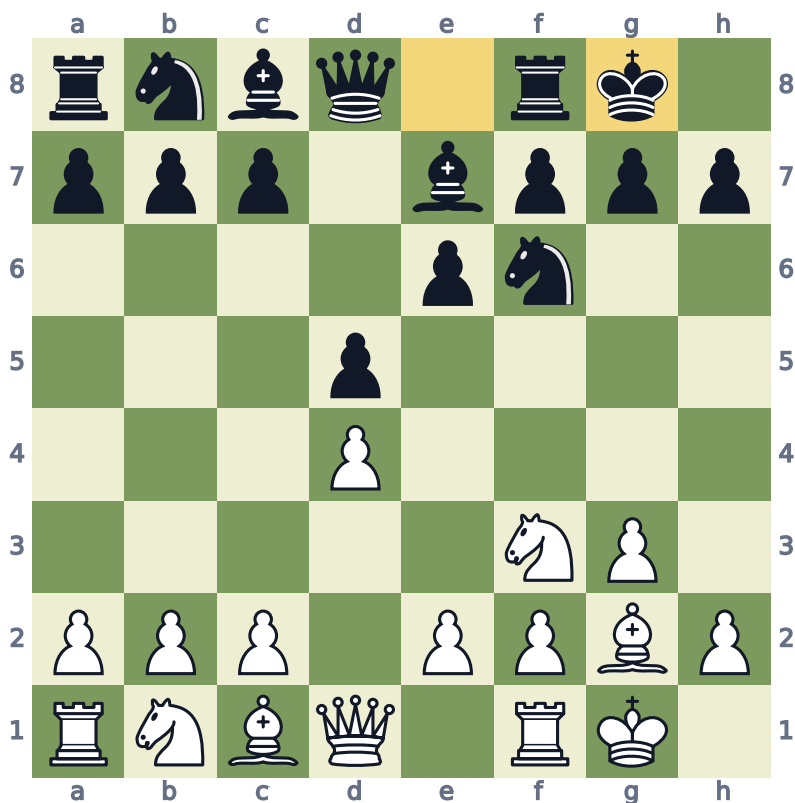
1. When Black already occupies e5, White's own e4 creates a symmetrical tension rather than the familiar e5 space wedge. 2. Black prepares ...d5, improves the pieces, and uses central equality to neutralize a slow kingside buildup. 3. White uses c3, Re1, and a timed d4 or f4 to create an imbalance instead of copying the closed French plan. 4. Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White? 5. Trying to play e5 into a well-supported black e5 pawn or maneuvering without creating tension.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Choosing d4 instead of d3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

DECISION RULE

Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns.

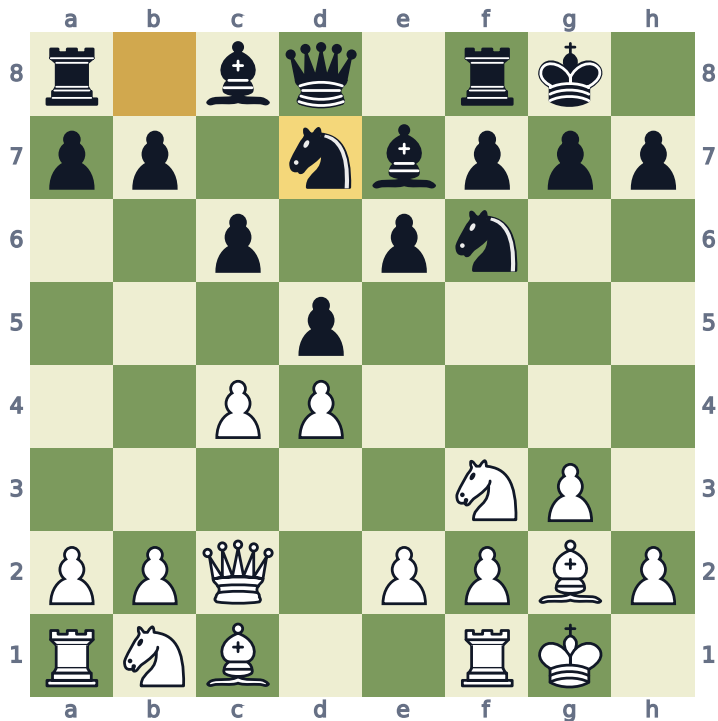
WHITE'S PLAN

White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell.

MEMORY RULE | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell.

CUE

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

FAILURE MODE

Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

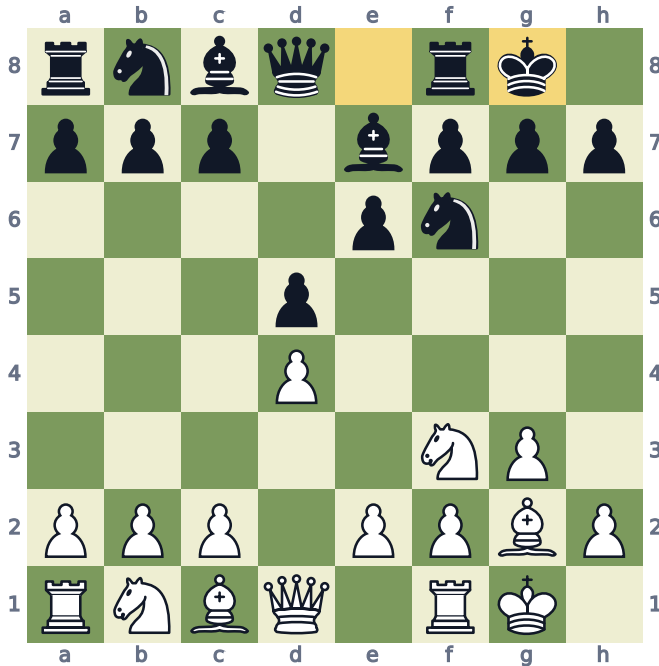
RULE | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d4 O-O 6. c4 c6 7. Qc2 Nbd7



- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d4: White changes the KIA shell into an open central fight.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? White's attacking or positional plan is: White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell. The line fails as a template when: Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

STORE THIS | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

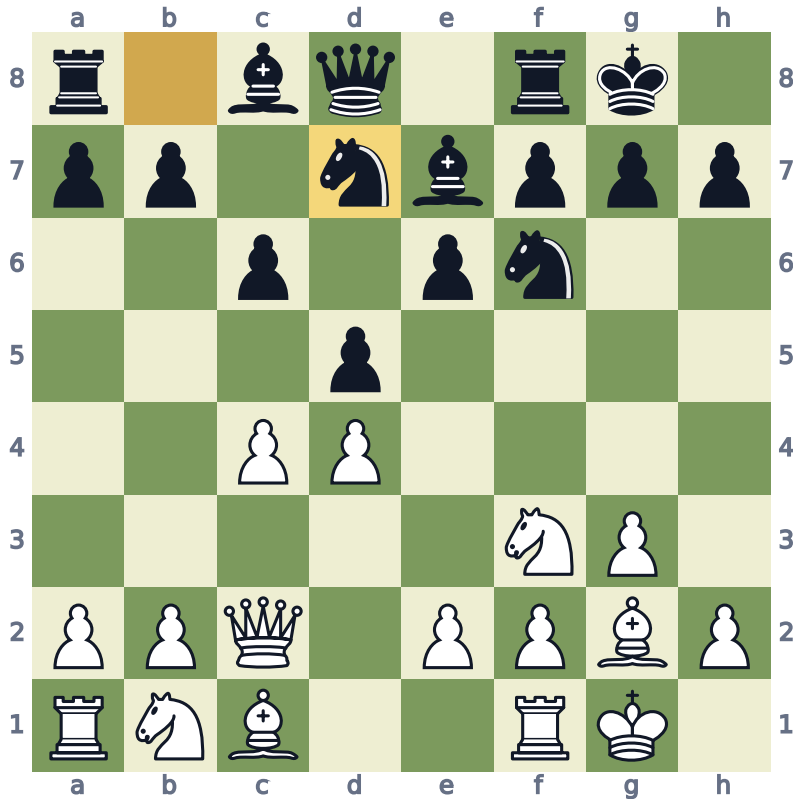
1. Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4. 2. Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns. 3. White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell. 4. Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? 5. Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d4 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Choosing d4 instead of d3



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

DECISION RULE

Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns.

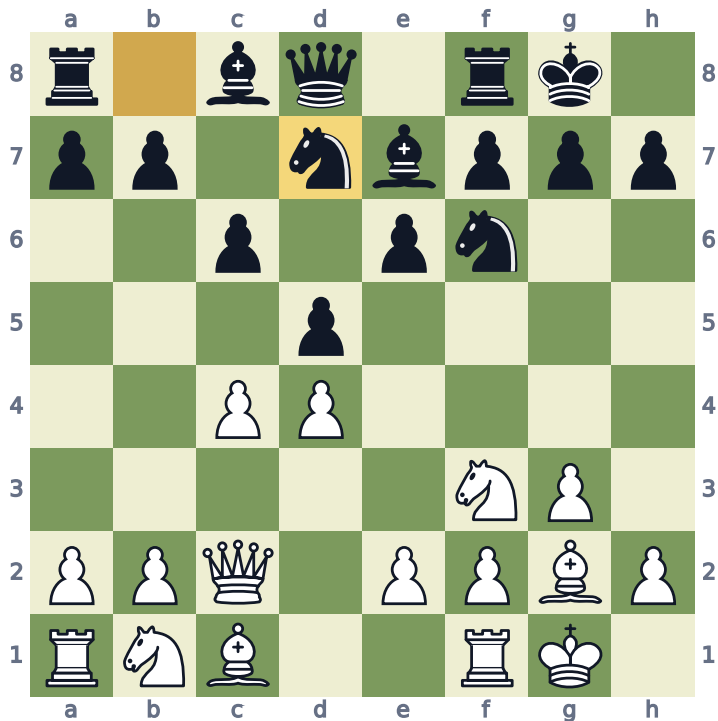
WHITE'S PLAN

White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell.

MEMORY RULE | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell.

FAILURE MODE

Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

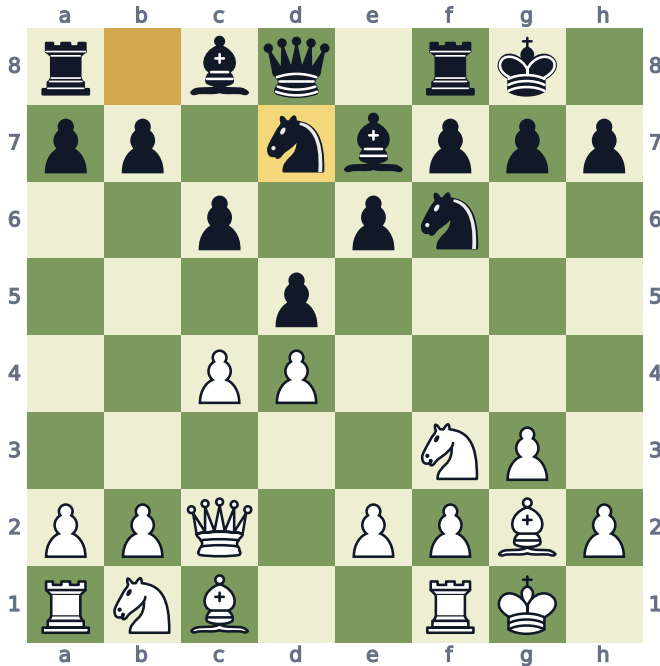
RULE | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d4 O-O 6. c4 c6 7. Qc2 Nbd7



- d4: White changes the KIA shell into an open central fight.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- c4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Qc2: White coordinates center and wing plans, but must check whether the queen becomes a tempo target.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? White's attacking or positional plan is: White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell. The line fails as a template when: Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

STORE THIS | The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Some black setups offer no useful e5 attack and allow White to claim a stronger classical center with d4 and c4. 2. Black builds a solid center, seeks ...b6 or ...dxc4, and challenges White to prove an advantage outside KIA patterns. 3. White accepts a Catalan or Réti-type structure because the center, bishop, and space work better than an automatic d3-e4 shell. 4. Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break? 5. Refusing a favorable center because it no longer carries the King's Indian Attack label.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d4 O-O 6. c4 c6 7. Qc2 Nbd7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 019 Decode: Delayed e4 against ...c5

Prompt: After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain?

Recall: Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

LESSON 020 Play: Delayed e4 against ...c5

Prompt: After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain?

Recall: Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

LESSON 021 Decode: Meeting Black's ...e5 center

Prompt: Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White?

Recall: Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

LESSON 022 Play: Meeting Black's ...e5 center

Prompt: Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White?

Recall: Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

LESSON 023 Decode: Choosing d4 instead of d3

Prompt: Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break?

Recall: The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

LESSON 024 Play: Choosing d4 instead of d3

Prompt: Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break?

Recall: The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Delayed e4 against ...c5

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 c5 3. Bg2 Nc6 4. O-O e5 5. d3 Nf6 6. Nbd2 Be7 7. e4 O-O 8. Re1

Decision: After e4, can Black play ...d4 with gain, and what square or break will White use against that chain?

Memory: Before e4, calculate Black's strongest pawn advance, not only its captures.

CARD 2

Meeting Black's ...e5 center

1. Nf3 d6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8

Decision: Which break, d4 or f4, changes the symmetry on terms favorable to White?

Memory: Against Black's ...e5, the KIA needs a break; the French attacking script no longer applies.

CARD 3

Choosing d4 instead of d3

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d4 O-O 6. c4 c6 7. Qc2 Nbd7

Decision: Does d3 preserve useful flexibility, or does d4 claim space without allowing Black an active break?

Memory: The KIA is a tool, not a vow; take the center when Black gives it safely.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
019 Decode: Delayed e4 against ...c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
020 Play: Delayed e4 against ...c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
021 Decode: Meeting Black's ...e5 center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
022 Play: Meeting Black's ...e5 center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
023 Decode: Choosing d4 instead of d3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
024 Play: Choosing d4 instead of d3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.